

The true spirit of competition



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"The next step? Ideathons. All great actions are conceived from great ideas. Marry them with technology and we have the potential for really solving some of our planet's clear and present dangers."

I've often wondered about the life of a school student here in India. Caught in a perpetual rat race with no end in sight, the minds of our young and hopeful are stripped of their awe and wonder. Imagination is beaten out of us with all the cramming, and good grades are all we can derive pleasure from, or rue forever. There is no room or time for good old, wide-eyed dreaming. We've all experienced this feeling of being creatively imprisoned at some point in our school life. I have healthy, civil debates on the subject with my wife who recently started teaching at a school.

A constant facet of school life, however, was the stream of competitions – unit tests and semesters included. And the various prizes – best dressed, best house, best disciplined, never missed a school day, and student of the year. Did it truly motivate the troops or merely divide the factions even more? Be that as it may, what cannot be argued is that it fostered a spirit of constant competition among the students; and a competitive spirit is priceless.

I always thought these school-, college- or university-level competitions could be more than just about ego battles or bragging rights, for both students and the teaching staff alike. For instance, why compete in sprinting or cricket alone – why not judge a team's or individual's performance based on how well they clean a beach? Along with drawing trees on paper and assessing their artistic value, why not also take the class out to a deforested area and have a planting competition? I'm sure college and university students, our able-bodied young adults, would like to compete against each other over who builds or repairs rural school structures better – give them a fresh coat of paint, make them more inviting for kids. Social competitions, for lack of a better word, can truly be transformative in helping change the status quo of competitions as they exist now to catalyze and add to the pace of social change.

The next step? Ideathons. All great actions are conceived from great ideas. Marry them with technology and we have the potential for really solving some of our planet's clear and present dangers. Things like climate change, space exploration, water and food production, global poverty, education, skill development, and many other aspects of our lives that can be improved upon through science and technology.

The best part? There are plenty of competitions that need your ideas to help make a positive impact on the world. Two examples of national

level competitions that I want to draw your attention towards are the National Innovation Fund (nif.org.in) and India International Science Festival (iisf2015.org).

The NIF is particularly inclusive of students and non-students from our country's villages to strengthen the rural technological innovations story. Since 2000, it claims to have built a database of more than 2,11,600 technological ideas, innovations and traditional knowledge practices from over 575 districts of the country, recognising more than 775 grassroots innovators and school students at the national level. NIF has filed over 725 patents (including eight in the US, and 27 PCT applications) on behalf of the innovators thus far. Inspiring stuff.

Similarly, the IISF is all about involving and including commonfolk with a view to improve their scientific understanding, temperament and appreciation of scientific and technological feats. It also aims to showcase innovative practices and achievements by the Indian science and technology system. IISF also has a Young Scientist's Conference, for which it's currently inviting ideas and proof-of-concepts on topics ranging from improving agricultural practices and livestock management, inclusive healthcare, remote sensing applications, green energy, waste to wealth technologies, climate change, among many other themes.

All I've done is highlight two national competitions here, which reward innovative tech ideas and concepts. There are plenty more, organised by tech companies such as Google, Microsoft, Intel and others. There may even be hundreds of local competitions in your state, city, or even locality, and I would encourage you or the students in your house to take part. If you're not a student, at least lend your time and support such initiatives. It will make a difference, trust me.

We should stop competing merely for the sake of competition, or monetary success alone. No doubt we need to keep the competitive spirit alive, but focus that energy on problems that really matter, not on simple ego massaging. What do you think? 

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